



communities surrounding the Adani Group's businesses and beyond. At present, it operates in 5,753 villages across 19 states, impacting the lives of 7.3 million people.

Through its initiative Sathwaro, meaning together, the Foundation works towards preserving India's rich heritage of arts and crafts while uplifting artisans in alignment with the SDGs. It helps artisans with design development so that they can produce as per the demands of the market. The initiative also provides support to artisans in forming market linkages to help them sell their products.

In Vizhinjam, Abdul Rehman was facing challenges as his products would get rejected for failing to meet market standards. A school dropout, he is a proud owner of a coconut shell handicraft business, which he built himself. His products – he makes around 40 items of kitchenware, tableware, garden, and décor – would sell at good prices. But these lost sheen as competition intensified. He then began to take part in exhibitions organized by the Foundation, which had begun working in the Vizhinjam port area. At the exhibitions, he learned the importance of marketing and quality control which helped him with design precision and in maintaining the quality of craft items on a par with export standards. The Sathwaro exhibition held on the premises of the port for a high-level delegation opened new channels, energising him to produce top quality items.

Rahman, who lost his father early and met with a freak accident while playing football that left him with a deformed limb, takes challenges head-on. This first-generation entrepreneur found his calling early in life, and the Sathwaro initiative gave a new direction to his passion.

Soga Mary of Muthukuru village in Nellore has a general nursing and midwifery (GNM) certificate. Her husband is an autorickshaw driver and the sole earning member of the family that includes their children and her parents-in-law. Life was difficult because her every wish to work and help her husband run their household met with a cold response from her in-laws. They didn't want her to go out and work. She decided to take the reins of her life and start something of her own. The Adani Foundation had begun work in the Krishnapatnam port area and when word reached her that they were extending support to people to start their own enterprise, she approached them. "I knew bamboo craft making and wanted to start my own enterprise from home,"



said Mary. But she did not have money to buy materials like bamboo sticks, wire for handles and other equipment required to make items that she was adept at.

The Foundation helped her with the required materials in bulk to start the micro-enterprise. "My happiness knew no bounds when I received my first payment. Today, I earn Rs 6,000 a month by selling handicraft items like bamboo baskets, light covers, trays, flower baskets, etc. This has given me immense confidence as I am able to contribute to household expenditure and save a good sum every month for my future," said Mary, who has built a rewarding life for herself.

The Sathwaro Mela held recently at Adani Corporate House (ACH), Ahmedabad, featured an inspiring array of handmade products made by 20 SHGs and artisans from across the country. The event bridges the gap between artisans and consumers. Through this platform, the Foundation aims to promote sustainable livelihoods and economic growth.

From Singrauli's (Madhya Pradesh) Sikki craft to Mundra's (Gujarat) Soonf and mud work to Maharashtra's Warli art to Kattupalli's (Tamil Nadu) palm leaves products and Vizhinjam's (Kerala) coconut shell items, a variety of handicrafts were on display. The exhibition received an overwhelming response from the visitors, who had so many traditional and contemporary crafts – each narrating a story of India's cul-

tural richness – to choose from.

Standing at her stall and explaining the craft of Sikki painting to a potential buyer gave Usha a sense of pride. She always wanted to do something on her own and the Sathwaro initiative gave wings to her dream. "Sikki painting is difficult; it is created out of paper made from golden stems of Sikki grass, which the women make themselves," she says. She is confident that with the Foundation's support she and her group will be able to reap benefits that will translate into profits.

The Sathwaro Mela also gave space to dying arts like Rogan, which has roots in Kutch, Gujarat. This traditional textile technique involves intricate and colourful patterns on fabric using castor-based paints. Unfortunately, only one family is now practising this art form. Another dying craft, practiced only by few artisans and showcased at ACH, was Surat's Sadeli craft, which involves an intricate combination of wood and metal to create geometric patterns, resulting in stunning and colourful veneer work.

The artisans often struggle due to lack of access to contemporary markets. The Foundation's objective is to provide them a platform where they can showcase products and sell them at a profitable rate. The Sathwaro Mela at ACH was an initiative to link the artisans to Adani's corporate gifting programme and open the doors to a potentially profitable market. It aims to provide artisans a steady income source, significantly enhancing their financial stability.

"There's a requirement to contribute towards maintaining cultural identities at the national level," says Mr Vasant Gad-havi, Executive Director, Adani Foundation. "There is also a need to promote cultural handicrafts globally that will generate awareness and support artisans and their crafts. Through the revival of ancient crafts, Sathwaro aims to inspire the younger generation to carry forward their cultural legacies. It also aims to align with SDGs related to economic growth, sustainable livelihood and cultural preservation." Sathwaro means together and its logo embodies unity, representing the strength of holding and embracing one another. Sustaining art and artisans, Sathwaro strives to empower artisans through fresh and contemporary designs while meeting modern demands. At the exhibitions, artisans learn the importance of marketing and quality control that help them with design precision and maintaining the quality of craft items as per the demands of the market.